
The Skill We Keep Teaching

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Teaching young people to spot a fake is, by almost any measure we have agreed to use, working. A 2024 meta-analysis of forty-nine experiments found that media-literacy training improves people's discernment between true and false, lowers their belief in misinformation, and sharply cuts how willing they are to share it^{[2][1/2]}. Twenty-five states have now written some form of media literacy into law. The case for more of it is easy to make, and I am inclined to make it.

2 And yet the studies that measure all this measure the wrong room. Almost none of them, only one in forty, look at what a person actually does online afterward; the rest record what people say they intend to do, or what they get right on a quiz. The gap matters more than it sounds, because the place we are trying to fix is not the quiz. It is the feed.

3 What we call a misinformation problem might be better described as an attention problem wearing the costume of a misinformation problem. The distinction is not a quibble. A platform does not lift a false story toward you because it is false; it lifts the story because the story keeps you there, and your staying is the thing being sold. The economist Herbert Simon noticed the shape of this in 1971: a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention, and attention becomes the scarce good everyone competes for. Falsehood, it turns out, is unusually good at being interesting.

4 So the curriculum and the algorithm are not really opponents. They are working different problems. The lesson trains the reader; the system pays for the reader's gaze regardless of what the reader has learned, and the payment does not stop when the lesson ends. One report this year clocked false stories traveling roughly six times faster than true ones. A classroom can make a student slower and more careful. It cannot make a lie less profitable to circulate.

5 There is something almost reassuring in that mismatch, and the reassurance is the part worth distrusting. A literacy mandate is visible, fundable, and easy to feel good about; it lets a legislature, a school board, a parent point to a thing that was done. Most of the new mandates arrived faster than the teacher training and the up-to-date materials did, so much of what is taught still describes a 2019 internet. The point is not that we are doing nothing. The point is that doing this lets the harder thing go unexamined.

6 I am not arguing against teaching it. The skill is real and the effect is real. I am only noticing that we have defined the problem as a deficit of skill in the reader, when the deficit that pays the bills sits one layer down, in an economy that would rather hold your attention with a lie than lose it to the truth. We taught the swimmer. We left the current alone.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer claims a platform amplifies a false story not because it is false but because it keeps the reader engaged. This claim functions primarily to
 - A) recast the misinformation debate as a question of economic incentive rather than reader skill
 - B) warn readers to distrust any story that holds their attention for long
 - C) prove that false stories are inherently more interesting than true ones
 - D) concede that platforms cannot be held responsible for what their systems promote
2. The final two sentences of the closing paragraph, "We taught the swimmer. We left the current alone," most directly contribute to the writer's tone by
 - A) mocking the educators and lawmakers who built the curricula
 - B) landing the argument in plain, unhurried language that withholds alarm even as it names the failure
 - C) expressing open despair that the problem can never be addressed
 - D) issuing an urgent call for readers to abandon media-literacy programs

Discussion questions:

1. The writer concedes early that media literacy demonstrably works, then argues it addresses the wrong problem. How does granting the opposing case its real strength change the force of the reframe that follows?
2. The piece redefines a "misinformation problem" as an "attention problem." What is gained, and what might be lost or oversimplified, when an argument is won by redefining the terms rather than by adding new evidence?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that teaching individuals to detect misinformation leaves untouched the economic incentives that make false content profitable to spread. Write an essay that argues your own position on the following claim: that efforts to address misinformation should focus less on educating individual readers and more on changing the incentives that govern how platforms distribute content. In your response, develop a defensible position, support it with evidence and reasoning, and acknowledge a strong objection to your view.